

Chapter 30: No Longer Outside

Jenny started to notice something unsettling.

Austin wasn't outside her life anymore.

He was inside it.

Not loudly.

Not forcefully.

Just... steadily.

Like a presence that had found the correct place to exist and refused to move again.

She hated how natural it was becoming.

And she hated even more that she wasn't fighting it the way she used to.

He was already at the counter when she came in.

No table today.

No waiting.

Just standing there like he belonged in the middle of her workspace.

Jenny stopped.

"...You're not sitting?"

Austin shook his head.

"No."

"Why?"

"I wanted to see you immediately."

Jenny sighed.

"You say things like that too easily now."

"I stopped filtering them," he said.

"That's not always good."

"I know."

A pause.

Then Jenny muttered,

"You're becoming impossible to argue with."

"I'm not trying to argue."

"That's the problem."

That almost made him smile.

Almost.

But it faded quickly, like everything else that had softened in him recently.

Jenny noticed that too.

Of course she did.

The day passed differently.

Not because anything changed externally.

But because Austin no longer behaved like a visitor.

He didn't sit back.

He didn't watch from distance.

He existed *within reach*.

Near the counter.

Near the kitchen entrance.

Near her pauses between tasks.

Jenny felt it constantly.

And it made her hyper-aware of everything she did.

Bao noticed immediately.

"He's closer than before," he said quietly.

Jenny didn't look up.

"I know."

"You're not reacting the same way anymore."

Jenny hesitated.

"...I'm working."

Bao smirked slightly.

"That's not an answer."

Jenny didn't respond.

Because it wasn't.

When the restaurant slowed, Jenny finally turned to him.

"You're not giving me space anymore," she said.

Austin looked at her.

"I am giving you space."

Jenny frowned.

"No, you're not."

"I'm not forcing closeness," he corrected.

"I'm allowing it when it exists."

That made her pause.

"...That sounds like manipulation."

"It isn't," he said calmly.

"It's restraint."

Jenny studied him.

"You're changing how you operate."

"Yes."

"Why?"

Austin didn't hesitate.

"Because I realized distance doesn't make me feel better."

That landed quietly.

Jenny looked away.

Of course she did.

But she didn't walk away this time.

Later, when the last customers left, Austin didn't move toward the door immediately.

He stayed near her.

Closer than before.

Jenny noticed that too.

Of course she did.

"You're not leaving?" she asked.

"I am."

"When?"

"After I say something."

That made her pause.

"...What?"

Austin looked at her for a moment.

Not intense.

Just steady.

Then he said quietly,

"I don't think I'm interested in staying outside your life anymore."

Jenny blinked.

"...Outside?"

"Yes."

A pause.

Then—

"I think I'm already inside it."

Silence.

That word again.

Inside.

Jenny felt something tighten in her chest.

"You make it sound like I had no choice in that," she said quietly.

Austin shook his head.

"I didn't enter without you noticing."

Jenny frowned.

"...I noticed?"

He nodded.

"Yes."

A beat.

Then softer—

"You just didn't stop me."

That made her still.

Because that was true.

Uncomfortably true.

Jenny looked down for a second.

Then back up.

"And now?" she asked quietly.

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Then—

"Now I stop acting like I might leave."

Jenny's breath caught slightly.

"...That sounds permanent."

"It is," he said.

Jenny swallowed.

"That's not normal."

"I know."

"That's not how people do things."

"I know."

A pause.

Then she whispered,

"...Why me?"

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then said simply,

"Because you became the only place I don't want to step out of."

Silence.

The restaurant felt too still again.

Jenny didn't have a quick response.

So she did what she always did when things became too real.

She turned slightly toward the back.

"I need to lock up."

Austin nodded once.

"I'll walk you."

Jenny hesitated.

Then quietly—

"...Okay."

But this time...

She didn't say it like permission.

She said it like acknowledgement.

Of something already happening.

And Austin didn't follow her like before.

He simply walked beside her.

Like he was no longer outside anything at all.